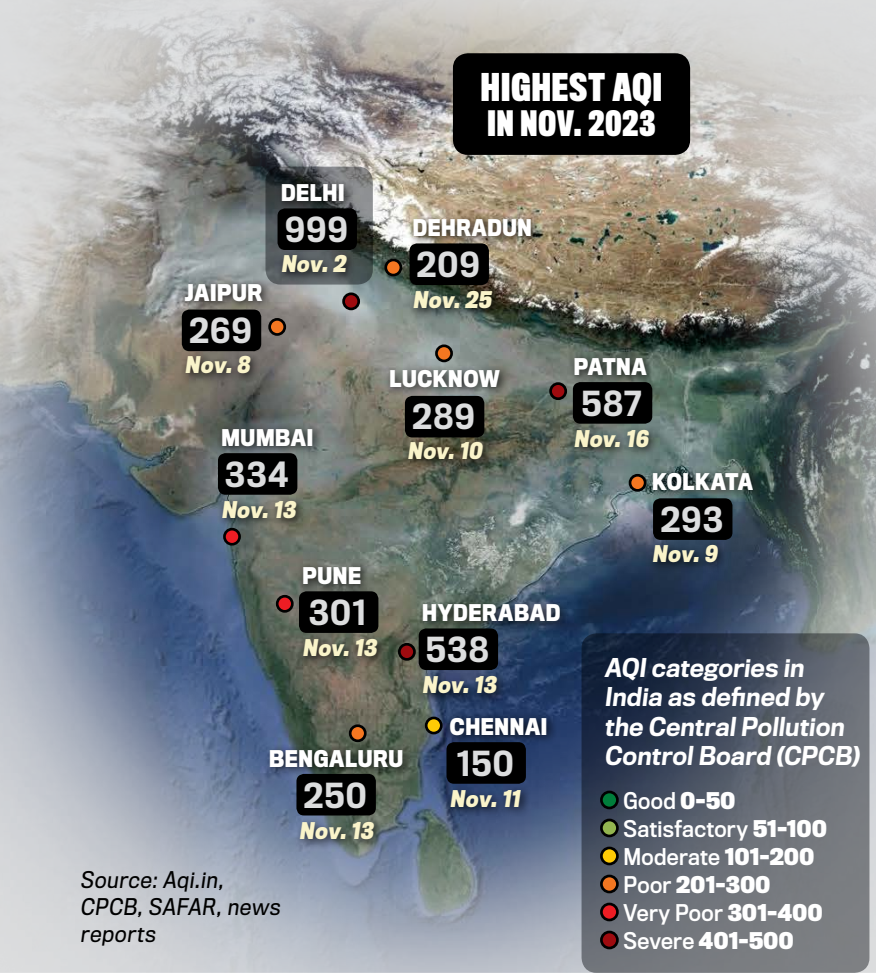
IN MARCH THIS YEAR, 39 OF THE TOP 50 POLLUTED CITIES IN THE WORLD WERE IN INDIA, ACCORDING TO IQAir



Source: Aqi.in, CPCB, SAFAR, news reports

PATNA

- In October, the Bihar capital was India's second most polluted city. It has over 2 mn vehicles and 1,000 under-construction projects

HYDERABAD

- Vehicle exhausts are the city's single biggest bane. The Telangana capital has over 7 mn vehicles, 2,000-plus industries

CHENNAI

- Around 4.8 mn vehicles ply on Chennai's roads. The Metro rail construction has aggravated dust pollution levels

JAIPUR

- PM concentration is the obvious concern in the desert city. Road dust accounts for 72 per cent of PM10 levels

PUNE

- Vehicular load and industries are the main factors. Two-wheelers are also a culprit here, some 3 mn vroom around on the city roads

LUCKNOW

- The UP capital's chaotic roads groan under 3 mn vehicles, 500,000 added in the last 5 years. Garbage burning is a blight too

DEHRADUN

- A gateway to the Himalayan foothills, it was the world's 31st most polluted city in 2018. Vehicular traffic must again take blame

BENGALURU

- Vehicular emissions make up 40 per cent of PM2.5 pollution. The garden city has over 11.3 mn vehicles for some 13 mn people

a common cold saw 38-year-old Anjali Malhotra, a schoolteacher in Delhi, laid up in bed for 10 days. The longer recovery times for respiratory ailments are becoming increasingly common and an issue of concern for doctors. Persistent weakness, fever that takes longer to subside and blocked airways are symptoms that many a flu patient is reporting to Dr Nangia this year, along with the fact that they have never felt like this before. "If you are breathing in toxins, it only adds stress to your body, which is already fighting against an infection," he says.

OTHER ORGANS THAT POLLUTION TARGETS

After the lungs, it's the heart that succumbs to the effects of pollution. A 2016 article in the medical journal *Lancet* first postulated that long-term



"POLLUTION IS NOT JUST PM2.5. ANY TOXIC GAS IN SIGNIFICANT AMOUNT CAN BE CARCINOGENIC, TRIGGER INFLAMMATION"

DR RAJESH CHAWLA
Pulmonologist, Apollo Hospitals, Delhi

exposure to particulate matter and high levels of nitrogen oxide can age blood vessels prematurely and contribute to a more rapid calcium buildup in the coronary artery. This, in turn, can reduce the flow of blood to the heart, precipitating strokes and heart attacks. According to the British Heart Foundation, pollution can affect even the heartbeat, triggering abnormal heart rhythms and changes in the heart structure akin to those in early stage heart failure. "Pollutants have been directly linked to cardiovascular disease and events," says Dr Balbir Singh, chairman of cardiac sciences at the Max Super Speciality Hospital in Saket, Delhi. "For those already suffering from heart issues, high pollution days are also extremely risky."

Science, too, has been shedding new light on what pollutants can do to the